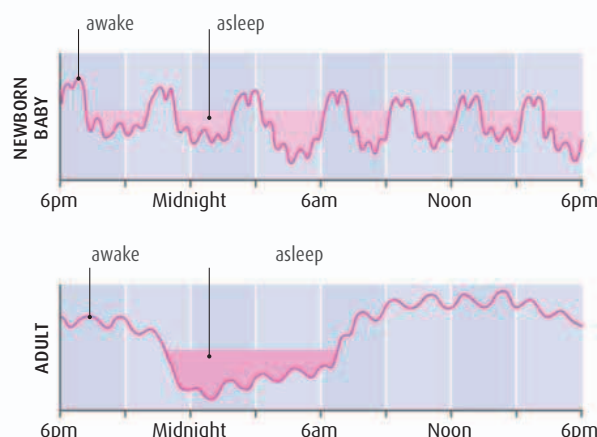


# Q How much sleep does my baby need?

On average, babies sleep 14–18 hours per day in the first few weeks. This time spent in slumber is vital for their growth and development.

Babies grow at a tremendous rate in the first few months. The time they spend asleep allows their bodies to focus on growing (growth hormone is released during sleep), and for them to process all the new information they receive each day. Newborns can manage only brief periods of sleep before their tiny tummies need to be fed again, so their sleep is spread over both night and day and they will wake as frequently at night as they do in the day. Aside from needing to wake often to be fed, your baby has short sleep cycles of 45–60 minutes, and when he stirs from a cycle, he finds it hard to drop back off naturally. All of this means that in the first six to eight weeks, you will need to feed your baby around the clock, waking every two to three hours at night to tend to him. At around two months (later for some, earlier for others), your baby will start to manage slightly longer stretches of sleep at night, and slightly shorter stretches during the day: his tummy will be bigger and his awareness of night and day is kicking in.



**Amounts of sleep** A newborn baby spends 16 hours asleep on average each day (this can range from 12 to 20 hours). The average adult requires half this amount of sleep.

## AVERAGE SLEEP BY AGE

While each baby has different needs, the following is a rough guide to what you can expect for your baby's sleep over the first three months of life:

| NEWBORN                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  | ONE MONTH                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    | TWO MONTHS                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      | THREE MONTHS                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>As a new baby:</b> he sleeps about 14–18 hours in every 24 hours, with about 7½ hours in the day, and 8½ hours at night. <b>During the day</b> sleep is divided into 3–4 periods of sleep. <b>At night</b> your baby will wake up every two to three hours to be fed. | <b>At one month:</b> your baby sleeps about 15½ hours in every 24 hours, with around 6–7 hours of sleep during the day, and 8½ hours sleep at night. <b>During the day</b> sleep is divided into about three nap times. <b>At night</b> your baby will still wake around two to three times. | <b>At two months</b> your baby will sleep about 15½ hours in every 24 hours, with around 5½ hours sleep during the day, and around 10 hours at night. <b>During the day</b> sleep is divided into about three nap times. <b>At night</b> your baby may manage slightly longer periods of sleep. | <b>At three months:</b> your baby will sleep about 15 hours in every 24 hours, with about 5 hours during the day. <b>During the day</b> sleep is divided into 3 nap times. <b>At night</b> your baby may sleep for about 10 hours, with perhaps just one or two nighttime feedings. |

# Q Where is the best place for my baby to sleep? Should he be in a crib?

In the first six months of life, it's recommended that the safest place for your baby to sleep is in a bassinet or crib in a room with you at night and for daytime naps. Keeping your baby nearby means you will be aware quickly of his needs, and he will feel comforted to be close to you. If you'd like, you can put your baby in a crib from the beginning. However, a full-sized crib can be too big for a newborn baby, and he may be more comfortable in a bassinet for the first few weeks. It mimics the feeling of being cocooned in the uterus, and is portable. You may find that at about two

months, your baby is looking a bit cramped in his bassinet. He should be able to sleep with his arms out to the side, or flung up by his head, without touching either the side or top of the bassinet.

# Q Can I co-sleep with my newborn baby? What are the risks?

Sharing a bed with your new baby can feel like the most natural thing in the world. If you are breast-feeding, being in the same sleeping space means you can feed your baby as soon as he stirs, minimizing sleep disruption. Some studies also suggest that co-sleeping could actually help

to regulate babies' breathing, and that generally the sleep patterns of mother and baby become more synchronized. The mother may be more responsive to the baby's needs. Your baby is also likely to feel very secure being so close to you, and may settle back to sleep more easily. However, the American Academy of Pediatrics doesn't recommend co-sleeping (or bed-sharing) as a safe activity. If you choose to do it anyway, avoid doing it with infants younger than three months old, if anyone in the bed smokes, or if you smoked while pregnant or if anyone in the bed is excessively tired or taking medications or substances that make it hard to be aroused or awakened easily. Only use a firm mattress (not a soft surface) and keep all soft bedding (pillows, blankets, sheets) out of the bed.